Contents

PART III

THE ILLUMINATIVE WAY OF PROFICIENTS

CHAPTER PAGE

I. The Object of the Third Part and the Language of Spiritual Writers Compared with That of Theologians . . . 3
   - A. The Language of Spiritual Writers Compared with That of Theologians . . . 6
   - B. The Question Raised by the Language of the Mystics . . . 6
   - C. The Theological Bases of the Terminology of Spiritual Writers . . . 9
   - D. The Principal Terms of the Language of Spiritual Writers . . . 10
   - E. Mystical Hyperbole . . . 13
   - F. Comparison of the Language of Spiritual Writers and That of Theologians . . . 16
   - G. Which of These Two Terminologies Is the Loftier? . . . 18

II. The Entrance into the Illuminative Way . . . 21
   - A. The Fact of the Second Conversion in the Lives of the Servants of God . . . 23
   - B. The Necessity of the Second Conversion . . . 25

III. The Second Conversion According to Several Spiritual Writers . . . 30
   - A. The Second Conversion in *The Dialogue* of St. Catherine of Siena . . . 30
   - B. The Second Conversion According to Blessed Henry Suso and Tauler . . . 33

IV. The Passive Purification of the Senses and the Entrance into the Illuminative Way . . . 40
   - A. The Necessity of this Purification . . . 40

CHAPTER PAGE

B. How the Passive Purification of the Senses Is Produced . . . 43
C. The Cause of This State . . . 47
D. Note . . . 52

V. Conduct to Be Observed in the Night of the Senses . . . 54
A. Four Rules of Direction Relative to This State 54
B. Trials Which Ordinarily Accompany the Night of the Senses . . . 59
C. The Effects of the Passive Purification of the Senses . . . 61

VI. The Spiritual Age of Proficients: Principal Characteristics . . . 65
A. The Knowledge of God in Proficients . . . 65
B. The Love of God and of Souls in Proficients . 70

VII. The Spiritual Edifice in Proficients . . . 72

VIII. Prudence and the Interior Life . . . 77
A. Defects to Be Avoided . . . 79
B. Acquired Prudence and Self-control . . . 81
C. Infused Prudence . . . 84
D. Holy Discretion and the Gift of Counsel . . 86

IX. The Different Forms of Justice and the Education of the Will . . . 90
A. Commutative and Distributive Justice in Relation to the Interior Life . . . 92
B. Legal Justice, Equity, and the Formation of Character . . . 93
C. Justice and Charity . . . 96
D. The Virtues Connected with Justice in Christian Life . . . 96

X. Patience and Meekness . . . 99
A. Patience and Longanimity, Twin Columns of the Interior Life . . . 99
B. Supernatural Meekness and Its Fruits . . . 102

XI. The Value of Chastity and Its Spiritual Fruitfulness . . . 108
A. The Motive That Should Inspire Chastity . . 108
B. The Spiritual Fruitfulness of Chastity . . . 111

CHAPTER PAGE

XII. The Humility of Proficients . . . 117
A. Humility toward God . . . 118
B. Humility toward Our Neighbor . . . 122

XIII. The Humility of the Word Made Flesh and What Ours Should Be . . . 127
A. The Humility and Magnanimity of Christ . . 127
B. The Union of Humility and Christian Dignity 131

Appendix. The Glory of the Cross . . . 136

XIV. The Spirit of Poverty . . . 140
A. The Value of Voluntary Poverty . . . 141
B. The Fruitfulness of Voluntary Poverty . . 145
C. The Merit of the Vows . . . 147

XV. The Grandeur of Obedience . . . 149
A. The Type of Servitude from Which Obedience Delivers Us . . . 151
B. The Fruits of Obedience . . . 154

XVI. Simplicity and Uprightness . . . 158
A. Defects Opposed to Simplicity . . . 159
B. Veracity and the Interior Life . . . 160
C. Superior Simplicity, the Image of That of God 162

XVII. The Spirit of Faith and Its Progress . . . 168
A. The Nature of the Spirit of Faith . . . 168
B. The Growth of Infused Faith in Us . . . 171
C. The Excellence and the Power of the Spirit of Faith . . . 172
D. A Practical Manner of Living by the Spirit of Faith . . . 175

XVIII. Confidence in God; Its Certitude . . . 178
A. Defects to Be Avoided . . . 178
B. The True Nature of Christian Hope . . . 179
C. The Certitude of Hope . . . 180
D. The Qualities of Christian Hope . . . 181
E. Admirable Effects of Living Hope Confirmed by Trials . . . 184

XIX. The Love of Conformity to the Divine Will . 187
A. The Signs of Imperfect Love . . . 187
B. The Nature of Charity and the Marks of Its Progress . . . 188

CHAPTER PAGE

C. The Love of God and Our Natural Dispositions . . . 192
D. Progressive Conformity to the Signified Divine Will . . . 193

XX. Fraternal Charity, Radiation of the Love of God 199
A. Why Our Love of God Should Extend to Our Neighbor . . . 200
B. Efficacy of the Love of Charity . . . 202
C. The Compass and Order of Charity . . . 203
D. How to Make Progress in Fraternal Charity . 206

XXI. Zeal for the Glory of God and the Salvation of Souls . . . 213
A. The Motives of Zeal . . . 214
B. The Qualities of Zeal . . . 218
C. The Sources of Spiritual Progress and Divine Intimacy . . . 222

XXII. Docility to the Holy Ghost . . . 223
A. The Inspirations of the Holy Ghost . . . 224
B. The Ascending Gradation of the Gifts . . . 225
C. Conditions Required for Docility to the Holy Ghost . . . 233
D. Acts Which Prepare the Soul for Docility to the Holy Ghost . . . 234
E. The Harmonizing of Docility to the Holy Ghost with Obedience and Prudence . . 236
F. The Fruits of Docility to the Holy Ghost . . 237

XXIII. The Discerning of Spirits . . . 241
A. The Signs of the Spirit of Nature . . . 243
B. The Signs of the Spirit of the Devil . . . 245
C. The Signs of the Spirit of God . . . 246

XXIV. The Sacrifice of the Mass and Proficients . . . 249
A. Adoration . . . 251
B. Reparation . . . 252
C. Petition . . . 254
D. Thanksgiving . . . 255

XXV. The Communion of Proficients . . . 258
A. The Holy Table and the Unity of the Mystical Body . . . 259

CHAPTER PAGE

B. Communion and the Growth of the Mystical Body of Christ . . . 260
C. Communion and the Gift of Oneself . . . 263

XXVI. Devotion to Mary in Proficients . . . 265
A. True Devotion to Mary . . . 265
B. The Degrees of This Devotion . . . 266
C. The Fruits of This Devotion . . . 268

XXVII. The Universal Accessibility of the Mysticism of *The Imitation* . . . 272
A. The Mystical Character of *The Imitation* . . 273
B. The Dispositions Required or the Asceticism of *The Imitation* . . . 277

XXVIII. Contemplative Prayer . . . 279
A. The Passage from Acquired Prayer to Initial Infused Prayer . . . 279
B. The Passage from Meditation to Contemplation According to the Traditional Teaching Expressed by St. Francis de Sales . . . 279
C. The Principles of This Traditional Teaching According to St. Thomas . . . 281
D. The Acquired Prayer of Recollection and Passive Recollection According to St. Teresa . 284

XXIX. The Errors of the Quietists on Contemplation and Pure Love . . . 289
A. The Quietism of Molinos . . . 289
B. Semi-Quietism . . . 292
C. The Problem of Pure Love . . . 294
D. In What the Practice of Pure Love Consists 297

XXX. The Degrees of Contemplative Prayer in Proficients . . . 299
A. The Progress of Prayer and the Virtues . . 299
B. The Prayer of Quiet . . . 300
C. The Prayer of Simple Union . . . 302
D. Contemplative Prayer and Fervent Communion 304

XXXI. Questions Relative to Infused Contemplation . 307
A. The Principal Problem . . . 307
B. Accepted Definitions . . . 309
C. Intimate Nature of Infused Contemplation . . 312
D. The Progress of Infused Contemplation . . 315

CHAPTER PAGE

E. What Infused Contemplation Does Not Necessarily Require . . . 317
F. The Call to Contemplation . . . 319
G. The Direction of Souls in Relation to Contemplation . . . 324

XXXII. The New Elements in Infused Prayer . . . 327
A. Whether the Character of Newness Always Appears Clearly . . . 328
B. The Explanation of This Transition . . . 330
C. Reply to a Difficulty . . . 333
D. The Special Illumination of the Holy Ghost . 335
E. The Special Illumination of the Gift of Wisdom Sufficient for Infused Contemplation . . 337

XXXIII. The Agreement and Differences between St. Teresa and St. John of the Cross . . . 342
A. The Cause of These Differences . . . 342
B. Whether These Differences Have a Common Basis . . . 343
C. A Recent Objection . . . 346

PART IV

THE UNITIVE WAY OF THE PERFECT

SECTION I

The Entrance into the Unitive Way through the Night of the Spirit . . . 353

XXXIV. The Necessity of the Passive Purification of the Spirit, and the Prelude of the Unitive Way . . 356
A. The Defects of the Advanced . . . 358
B. The Depths of the Will to Be Purified . . . 360

XXXV. Description of the Passive Purification of the Spirit . . . 367
A. The Darkness in Which the Soul Has the Impression of Being . . . 367
B. The Revelation of the Majesty of God in This Darkness . . . 369

XXXVI. The Cause of the Passive Purification of the Spirit . . . 375
A. Purifying Infused Light and Spiritual Fire . . 375

CHAPTER PAGE

B. The Influence of the Gift of Understanding in This Purification . . . 378

XXXVII. The Transluminous Obscurity . . . 384
A. The Effect of Too Great a Light . . . 384
B. The Effect of Light on Weak Eyes . . . 386
C. The Fear of Consenting or of Having Consented to Temptations . . . 387
D. Confirmations . . . 388

XXXVIII. Conduct to Be Observed during the Purification of the Spirit . . . 392
A. Generous Acceptance . . . 392
B. Faith in the Mystery of the Cross . . . 394
C. The Love of Conformity and of Submission to God's Good Pleasure . . . 397

XXXIX. The Effects of the Passive Purification of the Spirit in Relation Especially to the Three Theological Virtues . . . 400
A. Negative Effects . . . 400
B. The Positive Effects of This Purification . . 403
C. The Purification of Faith . . . 406
D. The Purification of Hope . . . 410
E. The Purification of Charity . . . 414
F. Sufferings That Sometimes Accompany the Passive Purification of the Spirit . . . 418

XL. The Spiritual Age of the Perfect, Their Union with God . . . 422
A. Quasi-Experimental and Almost Continual Knowledge of God . . . 422
B. Loving God with One's Whole Mind . . . 425
C. The Indwelling of the Blessed Trinity in the Purified Soul . . . 426
D. The Signs of the Indwelling of the Blessed Trinity in the Purified Soul . . . 429

XLI. A Form of Perfect Life: the Way of Spiritual Childhood . . . 433
A. The Innate Qualities of the Child . . . 433
B. The Principal Virtues of the Child of God . 435
C. What Distinguishes Spiritual Childhood from Natural Childhood . . . 437

CHAPTER PAGE

SECTION II

THE HEROIC DEGREE OF THE VIRTUES 440

XLII. THE HEROIC DEGREE OF THE VIRTUES IN GENERAL . 441
A. The Distinctive Marks of Heroic Virtue . . 442
B. The Connection of the Virtues and Their Heroic Degree 445

XLIII. HEROIC AND CONTEMPLATIVE FAITH 450
A. The Firmness of Its Adherence 451
B. Promptness in Rejecting Error 453
C. The Penetration Which Causes Everything to Be Seen in the Light of Revelation . 453
D. The Victory of Heroic Faith over the Spirit of the World 455

XLIV. HEROIC HOPE AND ABANDONMENT 457
A. The Invincible Firmness of Perfect Hope . . 457
B. Trusting Abandonment and Unwavering Fidelity 460
C. The Heroic Confidence of the Saints Restores Hope in Their Companions 462

XLV. HEROIC CHARITY 465
A. Heroic Charity toward God, Perfect Conformity to His Will and Love of the Cross . . 465
B. Heroic Charity toward One's Neighbor: the Ardent Desire for His Salvation and Radiating Goodness toward All 468

XLVI. THE HEROIC DEGREE OF THE CHRISTIAN MORAL VIRTUES 472
A. Heroic Humility and Meekness 472
B. Heroic Fortitude and Magnanimity. . . . 473
C. Heroic Prudence 475
D. Heroic Justice 477
E. The Heroic Degree of the Religious Virtues . 479

XLVII. THE LOVE OF JESUS CRUCIFIED AND OF MARY IN THE UNITIVE WAY 480
A. Christ's Victory and Its Radiation 481
B. Devotion to Mary in the Unitive Way . . . 484

CHAPTER PAGE

SECTION III

THE FORMS AND DEGREES OF THE UNITIVE LIFE . . 488

XLVIII. PERFECT APOSTOLIC LIFE AND CONTEMPLATION . . 489
A. The Eminent Source of the Apostolate . . . 490
B. The Condition of the Apostolate and Its Fruitfulness 494

XLIX. THE LIFE OF REPARATION 497
A. The Life of Reparation in the Priest . . . 498
B. The Life of Reparation in All Those Who Have a Heavy Cross to Carry 500
C. A Great Example: the Reparatory Night of the Spirit in St. Paul of the Cross 502

L. THE INFLUENCE OF THE HOLY GHOST IN THE PERFECT SOUL 511
A. The Holy Ghost, Uncreated Gift 511
B. The Activity of the Uncreated Gift in Our Souls 513
C. Conclusion 517

LI. ARID MYSTICAL UNION AND ECSTATIC UNION ACCORDING TO ST. TERESA 519
A. Arid and Painful Mystical Union 519
B. Ecstatic Union; Its Manifestation and Nature . 521
C. What Distinguishes Rapture from Ecstasy . . 524
D. The Effects of Ecstatic Union 525
E. The Purification of Love 526

LII. THE TRANSFORMING UNION, PRELUDE OF THE UNION OF HEAVEN 527
A. The Graces Which Sometimes Accompany the Transforming Union 528
B. The Essential Nature of the Transforming Union 529
C. The Theological Explanation of This State . . 531
D. The Effects of the Transforming Union . . 533
E. A Note on the Highest Degree of the Mystical Life 539
1. The Nameless Depth of the Soul and the Deity 539

CHAPTER PAGE

2. The Holy Ghost Lifts up the Soul and Prays in It . . . 540
3. Detachment from Self and Attachment to God . . . 541
4. Different Meanings of the Title "Spouse" 542
5. The Desire of the Transforming Union . 544
6. The Intimacy of the Transforming Union 546
7. The Equality of Love . . . 546
8. Conclusion . . . 547

APPENDIX

THE PERFECTION OF LOVE AND THE MYSTICAL UNION 547

I. THE PERFECTION OF LOVE AND INFUSED CONTEMPLATION . . . 547

II. THE UNION DESCRIBED IN *A Spiritual Canticle* IS MYSTICAL . . . 550

III. THE PERFECTION OF LOVE IN THE SPIRITUAL ESPOUSALS 552

IV. THE PERFECTION OF LOVE IN THE SPIRITUAL MARRIAGE 557

PART V

EXTRAORDINARY GRACES

LIII. CHARISMS OR GRACES *Gratis Datae* . . . 575
A. Nature and Division of the Charisms . . . 575
B. Application of This Doctrine by St. John of the Cross . . . 577

LIV. DIVINE REVELATIONS AND VISIONS . . . 580
A. What Should Be Thought of Private Revelations 580
B. Supernatural Visions . . . 586

LV. SUPERNATURAL WORDS AND DIVINE TOUCHES . . . 589
A. The Different Kinds of Supernatural Words . 589
B. Divine Touches . . . 592

LVI. STIGMATIZATION AND SUGGESTION . . . 596
A. The Traditional Teaching . . . 597
B. Ecstasy and Stigmatization . . . 601
C. Levitation . . . 604
D. Luminous Effluvia . . . 605
E. Fragrant Effluvia . . . 605
F. Prolonged Abstinence . . . 606

CHAPTER PAGE

LVII. DIFFERENCES BETWEEN EXTRAORDINARY DIVINE FACTS AND MORBID PHENOMENA . . . 608
A. Differences on the Part of the Subject . . . 609
B. Differences on the Part of the Phenomena . . 610
C. Differences in the Effects . . . 611
D. An Examination of Some Particular Facts . . 613
E. Note . . . 615

LVIII. DIABOLICAL PHENOMENA . . . 617
A. Obsession . . . 618
B. Possession . . . 620
1. A Striking Example . . . 623
2. Note . . . 626

EPILOGUE

I

THE AXIS OF THE SPIRITUAL LIFE AND ITS UNITY . . 628
A. The Distinction between Ascetical and Mystical Theology as It Has Often Been Proposed Since the Seventeenth Century . . . 630
B. Disadvantages from a Wrong Understanding of the Division between Ascetical and Mystical Theology . . . 633
C. Various Forms of Simplified Prayer . . . 634
D. The Axis of the Spiritual Life and Ascetical Theology Rightly Understood . 637
E. The Axis of the Spiritual Life and True Mystical Theology . . . 638

II

THE BEATIFIC VISION AND ITS NORMAL PRELUDE . . 644
A. The Absolutely Immediate Vision of the Divine Essence . . . 644
B. The Normal and Immediate Prelude of the Beatific Union . . . 648

ADDENDA

ON THE NATURE OF SPIRITUAL THEOLOGY . . . 652

SYNTHESIS OF THE TREATISE ON *The Three Ages of the Interior Life* . . . 655

PAGE

Summary of the Work in Three Retreats
A. First Retreat: On Spiritual Progress . . . 656
B. Second Retreat: On the Spiritual Organism . 656
C. Third Retreat: On Christian Perfection . . 657

Index 659

Some Terms Used in This Book 669

PART III

The Illuminative Way of Proficients

Summary of the Work in Three Retreats

FIRST RETREAT: ON SPIRITUAL PROGRESS

1. The last end of life: celestial beatitude, II, 644–51; the life of grace, eternal life begun, I, 29–39.
2. Sin, its roots and consequences; the predominant fault, I, 299–322; tepidity, I, 389–96.
3. The redemptive love of Christ for us, I, 109–18; II, 128 ff., 480–87.
4. Charity toward God, II, 187–98, 465–68.
5. Charity toward one's neighbor, II, 187–98, 468–71.
6. Mortification, I, 275–98.
7. Humility, II, 117–39.
8. Poverty, II, 140–48.
9. Chastity, II, 108–16.
10. Holy obedience, II, 149–57.
11. The cross and purifications in general, II, 40–64, 356–99.
12. The prayer of petition and liturgical prayer, I, 428–43.
13. Mental prayer, I, 444–53.
14. Docility to the Holy Ghost, II, 223–48.
15. Devotion to Mary, II, 265–71.
16. How to live profoundly by the Mass, II, 249–64.
17. Holy Communion, II, 258–64.
18. Zeal for the glory of God and the salvation of souls, II, 213–21.

SECOND RETREAT: ON THE SPIRITUAL ORGANISM

1. The interior life, intimate conversation with God, I, 40–47, 48–51.

The Theological Virtues, I, 52–56

2. Faith, II, 168–77.
3. Hope and its certitude, II, 178–86.
4. Charity, II, 187–212.

The Moral Virtues, I, 57–66

5. Prudence and the interior life, II, 77–89.
6. The different forms of justice, II, 90–98.
7. Fortitude and patience, II, 99–107.

8. Chastity, II, 108–16.
9. Humility, II, 117–39.
10. Actual grace and its different forms, I, 88–96.
11. The Blessed Trinity present in us, I, 97–108.
12. The gifts of the Holy Ghost and docility to the Holy Ghost, I, 66–88; II, 223–48.
13. The influence of Christ the Redeemer on His mystical body, I, 109–18.
14. The influence of Mary Mediatrix, I, 119–28.
15. The growth of the life of grace through merit, prayer, the sacraments, I, 129–43.
16. Sacramental confession, I, 397–405.
17. Assistance at Mass, source of sanctification, I, 406–13; II, 249–57.
18. Holy Communion, I, 414–27; II, 258–64.

THIRD RETREAT: ON CHRISTIAN PERFECTION

1. Christian perfection, its true nature, I, 144–62.
2. The grandeur of Christian perfection and the beatitudes, I, 163–73.
3. Christian perfection and the precept of love, I, 196–205.
4. Christian perfection and the evangelical counsels, I, 206–13.
5. The special obligation of the priest and the religious to tend to perfection, I, 214–24.
6. The three ages of the spiritual life, I, 225–46.
7. The spiritual age of beginners, I, 265–74.
8. The purification of the senses and the imagination, I, 332–52.
9. The purification of the intellect and the will, I, 353–78.
10. Retarded souls, I, 461–72.
11. The spiritual age of proficients, II, 65–71.
12. The discerning of spirits, II, 241–48.
13. The Sacrifice of the Mass and proficients, II, 249–57.
14. The Communion of proficients, II, 258–64.
15. The mysticism of *The Imitation* accessible to all, II, 272–78.
16. The crosses of the sensible part of the soul and those of the spirit, II, 40–64, 356–99.
17. The spiritual age of the perfect, II, 422–32.
18. The beatific vision and its normal prelude, II, 644–51.